

# The Samurai: Elite Social Class [B1]

Temibili guerrieri, ma anche funzionari e artisti: un'esibizione del British Museum sfata i miti e le leggende che circondano l'élite militare del Giappone medievale.





When we think of a samurai, the first image that [springs to mind](#) is that of the [fearless](#) and honourable warrior who lives by the sword and dies in epic duels. A new exhibition at the British Museum [dispels](#) this popular myth, inviting visitors to question what they know and discover how the idea of the samurai has slowly formed over time.

## A MAJOR SHOW

Rather than telling one simple story, 280 objects along with digital media show how the samurai evolved greatly across a thousand years of Japanese history. The word 'samurai' derives from the Japanese verb 'sabarau' meaning 'to serve' and in the early years, especially from the 1100s [onwards](#), samurai were soldiers living through violent times. Fighting was their main role, and power came through military success. An exquisite [suit of armour](#), newly acquired by the museum, will be on display for the first time; its prestigious helmet and golden [standard](#), shaped like [iris leaves](#), were designed to make the [wearer](#) both identifiable and [fearsome](#).

## PEACE AT LAST

However, war did not last forever in Japan. After two hundred years of fighting, the country was unified and the 1600s [ushered in](#) a long period of peace when the samurai did not fight at all. Instead, they worked as bureaucrats and administrators; there were many ranks within the samurai class. When official roles became [scarce](#), many samurai became [indebted](#) and turned to monetising their hobbies, some becoming artists, for example. This part of samurai history is often forgotten, but it lasted much longer than the age of battles. Culture

Fionn mac Cumhaill: The Irish Legendary Warrior Una delle figure più popolari della mitologia celtica è il capo dei Fianna, un gruppo di potenti guerrieri, mercenari e banditi. Un'esperta di folclore irlandese ci racconta la storia di questo personaggio saggio e coraggioso. Talitha Linehan , Sarah Davison

## FEMALE WARRIORS

The exhibition also challenges another common belief: that samurai were only men. In fact, women made up half of the samurai class, playing many different roles in society. From the 12th to the 16th centuries, many women held positions of power. One [striking](#) object on display is a bright red [firefighting coat](#) worn by women at Edo Castle, where fires were frequent and dangerous.

## CULTURAL SYMBOL

Another theme of the exhibition is how the samurai became a cultural symbol. In the late 1800s, when the samurai class officially ended, stories about loyalty and sacrifice were promoted and helped shape a powerful national image. At the same time, people outside Japan became fascinated by samurai culture and some wealthy European visitors [commissioned](#) portraits of themselves as Japanese warriors, showing how samurai imagery captured Western imaginations. The exhibition traces the long and complex history of the samurai through paintings, [woodblock prints](#), books, clothing, ceramics, photographs, and modern media such as film, television, manga, video games, and contemporary art. It also features newly [commissioned](#) works by the celebrated Japanese artist Tetsuya Noguchi, [a testament to](#) how the samurai continue to inspire creativity today. Until 4 May 2026 [www.britishmuseum.org](http://www.britishmuseum.org)

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# Glossary

- **fearless** = coraggioso, impavido
- **dispels** = sfatare
- **onwards** = in avanti, in poi
- **suit of armour** = armatura
- **standard** = ornamento
- **iris leaves** = foglie di iris
- **fearsome** = temibile
- **ushered in** = segnare l'inizio
- **springs to mind** = venire in mente
- **scarce** = scarsi
- **striking** = sorprendente
- **firefighting coat** = cappotto antincendio
- **commissioned** = incaricare
- **a testament to** = testimonianza di
- **wearer** = portatore, indossatore
- **indebted** = indebitati
- **woodblock prints** = stampe su tavole di legno